



Iris

RHIZOMES
A rhizome is a usually horizontal stem produced by a perennial plant, either under ground or on the surface. As the rhizome spreads, it occasionally divides, producing roots, stems, and leaves. The oldest part of the rhizome may die away so that these new shoots form separate plants.

Iris rhizome

Jerusalem artichoke tuber

TUBERS

Tubers are swollen underground stems. They store food to produce new plants and also to help the parent plant to survive in adverse conditions. When gardeners and farmers lift tuber crops like potatoes, they have to be careful to dig up every one. If even part of the potato is left in the ground, it will sprout to produce a new plant the following spring.

Potato tuber

Stolon

Young plant forming at the tip of the stolon

Young plant grows from a bud at the leaf node

Runner

BULBS

A bulb consists of a bud surrounded by short and very swollen leaves, with flattened underground stems. Some bulbs, such as the tulip, produce one or more new bulbs around their base every year. These can be broken off the parent bulb to form new plants.

Tulip bulb

New bulbs form around the base of the old bulb

LEAVES THAT TAKE ROOT

Plants that live in dry places often have fleshy leaves that are full of water. If these leaves are broken off, they can survive for a long time, because they do not dry out as quickly as normal, thin leaves. While they are lying on the ground, many of them can put down roots and develop into new plants.

String-of-buttons plant

Fleshy leaves can root themselves

Sedum rubrotinctum

BULBS ABOVE AND BELOW GROUND

This species of onion has both bulbs and bulbils—small, bulblike structures that form above ground in place of flowers.

Bulbils may fall to the ground and take root

Top of the plant

Bulb under ground

Allium paradoxum